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U.S. DEPARTMENT OF HOMELAND SECURITY

**The Office of Program Accountability
and Risk Management (PARM)**



**MARITIME CAPABILITIES AND INNOVATION
COMMERCIAL SOLUTIONS OPENING PILOT
PROGRAM (CSOP)**

General Solicitation

Number 70RDA125Ro00000013

August 6, 2025

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MARITIME CAPABILITIES AND INNOVATION

COMMERCIAL SOLUTIONS OPENING PILOT PROGRAM (CSOP)

General Solicitation

Open for 12 Months Until August 5, 2026

Background

The National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA) for Fiscal Year (FY) 2017, Title VIII, § 880 (Pub. L. 114-328), Pilot Programs for Authority to Acquire Innovative Commercial Items Using General Solicitation Competitive Procedures (as amended), provided the statute for the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) to carry out a “Commercial Solutions Opening Pilot Program” (CSOP) to competitively procure innovative commercial products.

The CSOP is a non-Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) merit-based solution selection strategy for DHS to acquire innovative commercial products and services through the award of a contract. The CSOP vests Contracting Officers with additional procedural discretion and flexibility so that innovative commercial products and services may be solicited, offered, evaluated, and awarded in a simplified manner that maximizes efficiency and economy and minimizes burden and administrative costs for both the Government and industry. DHS has determined that under this pilot program, a General Solicitation can be executed to solicit proposals from industry. Each proposal is evaluated on its individual merits rather than on a comparative basis, and the Government has considerable latitude in determining which of the submitted proposals it will fund. As a result, DHS’s Office of Program Accountability and Risk Management (PARM) is issuing the subject General Solicitation for DHS and all its Components to rapidly procure innovative commercial maritime capabilities and solutions.

The Department’s maritime responsibilities span a wide array of missions, including homeland defense readiness, law, border, and trade enforcement, disaster response, counter-illicit trafficking, humanitarian response, and critical infrastructure protection. These missions depend on a broad ecosystem of platforms, technologies, port systems, and operational capabilities that must be acquired, sustained, and modernized in a fiscally responsible, secure, and mission-driven manner.

DHS Components—including the U.S. Coast Guard, U.S. Customs and Border Protection, the Federal Emergency Management Agency, the Transportation Security Administration, and others—operate in increasingly contested and complex maritime environments. These environments demand coordinated investment in both platforms and enabling systems, as well as a deliberate approach to oversight, digital modernization, industrial base health, and workforce readiness.

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The Under Secretary for Management, as the Department's Chief Acquisition Officer, is responsible for ensuring that DHS's maritime capabilities are delivered effectively, efficiently, and in support of national priorities. This includes not only acquisition of new vessels and craft, but also the transformation of how DHS approaches inspections, trade enforcement, sustainment, and maritime domain awareness. To this end, the Department is leveraging this General Solicitation to identify and invest in innovative, non-traditional, and cross-cutting solutions to improve outcomes across the maritime domain.

What are the goals of the DHS General Solicitation?

The Maritime Capabilities and Innovation General Solicitation aims to identify new ideas, approaches, tools, and partnerships that can help the Department address critical challenges and accelerate transformation across its maritime enterprise. This General Solicitation provides a flexible mechanism to solicit, evaluate, and fund exploratory and applied work that does not fit neatly into traditional acquisition frameworks, but that has the potential to improve DHS's ability to acquire, oversee, and operate with their maritime enterprise.

The goals of this General Solicitation are to:

- Advance U.S. maritime dominance goals through increased resilience in shipbuilding, port infrastructure, supply chains, and workforce development.
- Support mission-driven modernization of acquisition, sustainment, oversight, and operational execution across DHS's maritime activities;
- Expand collaboration with industry, academia, non-profits, and other non-traditional entities working on maritime technology, security, and logistics;
- Strengthen maritime acquisition outcomes by enhancing lifecycle planning, risk management, and component-level coordination;
- Enable innovative solutions to complex and persistent maritime challenges through applied research, technical insight, policy frameworks, or prototype concepts;

The procurement is limited to innovative commercial products or services. Within the meaning of the statute, innovative is defined as, "Any new technology, process, or method, including research and development, or any new application of an existing technology, process, or method."

This General Solicitation will stay open for a period of 12 months, **until August 5, 2026**. Industry is invited to respond to this open call for innovative solutions at any time during the stated period. Submissions will be accepted on a rolling basis, allowing for continuous engagement and the opportunity to present solutions as they are developed. The Government anticipates reviewing the Maritime Capabilities and Innovation CSOP mailbox approximately every (2) weeks to check for submissions.

This General Solicitation is intended to be used by any of the Components within the Department. For more information regarding the diverse mission space of DHS, please visit our public website at: <https://www.dhs.gov/>

This General Solicitation does not have a ceiling, but each individual CSOP contract/agreement awarded may not exceed \$25M. The Government anticipates that all

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CSOP awards will be Firm Fixed Price (FFP) but reserves the right to award utilizing other contract types if needed. One of the advantages of the CSOP authority is that the Government and Vendor together develop negotiable award terms (including payment, intellectual property and data rights license terms, schedule, milestones, and pricing.)

Who Can Participate?

All US-based entities are eligible to participate, including established Government Contractors, commercial companies, and small businesses as defined by SBA standards. Foreign companies may participate through established US subsidiaries that are incorporated in the United States and registered to conduct business domestically. Non-traditional vendors, such as academic institutions, research organizations, and non-profit entities are also encouraged to participate. Contract employees will be required to undergo a favorable Suitability Assessment as determined by the Department. In addition, the Contractor may be required to comply with Agency Personal Identity Verification procedures identified in the contract that implement Homeland Security Presidential Directive-12 (HSPD-12).

Submissions or proposals may be subject to Section 889, the Prohibition on Certain Telecommunications and Video Surveillance Services or Equipment, of the 2019 National Defense Authorization Act as applicable.

To be eligible for award, companies must be registered in the System for Award Management (SAM.gov), prior to DHS making a CSOP award.

Initial Strategic Focus Areas in the Maritime Domain

DHS operates across a diverse and complex maritime environment, encompassing homeland defense readiness, law, border, and trade enforcement, disaster response, counter-illicit trafficking, humanitarian response, and critical infrastructure protection. This General Solicitation invites novel concepts, tools, frameworks, and partnerships to help DHS address persistent and emerging problem sets across this domain. Proposed efforts should aim to improve mission outcomes, increase operational efficiency, and strengthen acquisition and sustainment of maritime capabilities.

DHS is seeking video solution submissions which are relevant to one or more of the following Strategic Focus Areas:

A. Maritime Technology Innovation and Digital Transformation

- DHS seeks innovative approaches to accelerate the responsible adoption of digital tools and engineering innovation across maritime missions and acquisitions. This includes improving how platforms and systems are designed, tested, deployed, and supported using data-driven and modern software-based approaches.

B. Program Oversight and Acquisition Risk Management

- Delivering maritime capabilities at speed and scale requires better oversight tools and risk-based decision-making. DHS is seeking innovative approaches to increase

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transparency and reduce acquisition risk across programs and Contracting strategies.

C. Lifecycle Sustainment and Operational Readiness

- Reducing the cost and complexity of sustaining both legacy and new maritime platforms is essential to long-term mission success. DHS is seeking innovative approaches to maintain asset availability, manage obsolescence, and align sustainment models with operational needs.

D. Supply Chain Resilience and Port Infrastructure Risk

- Ensuring visibility and resilience across maritime supply chains and infrastructure is a growing priority. DHS is looking for innovative methods to manage physical and digital risks that impact port operations, vessel systems, and critical industrial partnerships.

E. Trade Enforcement and Inspection Innovation

- Improving the effectiveness and efficiency of maritime inspections is vital to securing the flow of lawful trade. DHS is interested in innovative concepts that enhance inspection capabilities, targeting tools, and data integration in support of trade enforcement.

F. Maritime Interdiction and Counter-Illicit Activity

- DHS is focused on strengthening detection, tracking, and interdiction of illicit maritime activity, including drug trafficking, human smuggling, illegal fishing, and weapons transport. DHS is seeking innovative solutions that enhance maritime domain awareness, accelerate interdiction response, and reduce operational burden.

G. Maritime Workforce and Industrial Base Development

- A capable workforce and resilient industrial base are essential to DHS's maritime mission execution. The Department is seeking innovative ways to build talent pipelines, support industrial capacity, and foster Government-industry-academic collaboration.

Note: This initial list of Strategic Focus Areas may evolve over time. The General Solicitation is designed to be dynamic and adaptable, reflecting the evolving nature of our requirements. Consequently, the Strategic Focus Areas may be revised periodically throughout the duration of the Solicitation as our maritime objectives and needs develop. Throughout the open period, DHS may issue Amendments to the Solicitation to change the Strategic Focus Areas or provide more detailed information related to a specific Strategic Focus Area. These Amendments may include specific instructions and/or due dates.

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Submission Guidelines

Phase 1 –Solution Videos

Interested parties may continuously submit video solutions throughout the open period of the General Solicitation.

- Solution videos should be submitted in the following format:
 - Videos should be no longer than five (5) minutes in length and uploaded via unique link to YouTube (www.youtube.com) or Vimeo (www.vimeo.com)
- Solution video shall (at a minimum) include the following content:
 - Confirm and clearly describe that the technology solution proposed is a commercial item/solution.
 - Confirm and clearly describe that the technology solution proposed is innovative or how the commercial solution is offered in an innovative manner.
 - Identification of the Strategic Focus Area(s) addressed.
 - Description of the solution and relevant application to Strategic Focus Area(s).
 - Differentiators (company content choice).
- Solution videos must be accompanied by a written solution brief that shall be emailed to the CSOP mailbox at, parminfo@hq.dhs.gov, and include the following information:
 - Cover Letter including;
 - Solution Title
 - Link to Solution Video
 - Company Name, Point of Contact Name, Phone Number, Unique Entity Identifier Number, Email Address, and Address
 - Maximum 1 page
 - Executive Summary of the Technology; relevant to Strategic Focus Area(s)
 - Maximum 2 pages per Strategic Focus Area
 - If your written submission contains proprietary information, please mark accordingly.
 - Previous award(s) on similar topic(s) (e.g. SBIR Awards, OTA)
 - Maximum 1 page

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Basic Eligibility Requirements, Disclaimers, and General Information

- A single entity may submit multiple solution videos throughout the term of the General Solicitation.
 - Each video submission requires a completed entry via email (with video link and written solution briefing) to the mailbox: parminfo@hq.dhs.gov.
- Solution videos shall be unclassified, and must not include any proprietary information, export-controlled information or controlled unclassified information (CUI).
- Written solution briefs containing proprietary information must be clearly marked as proprietary. The submitter shall include the following sentences on the cover page: “This solution brief includes data that shall not be disclosed outside the Government, except to non-Government personnel for evaluation purposes, and shall not be duplicated, used or disclosed – in whole or in part – for any purpose other than to evaluate this submission. If, however, an agreement is awarded to this Company as a result of – or in connection with – the submission of this data, the Government shall have the right to duplicate, use, or disclose the data to the extent agreed upon by both parties in the resulting agreement.”
- All costs of preparing and submitting solution videos and written submission are the responsibility of the submitting entity and not eligible for funding or reimbursement by the Government.

How Your Solution Video Submission Will Be Assessed

DHS anticipates checking the CSOP mailbox approximately every (2) weeks for Phase 1 submissions. The assigned Peer Review Team will evaluate submissions within approximately (10) working days. Solutions will be assessed by DHS personnel to determine whether the vendor’s submission has merit relative to evaluation criteria. During the assessment period, DHS may engage in exchanges with submitting entities regarding technical, price, or any other aspects of their submissions. DHS, in its sole discretion, may engage in exchanges with only one, some, all, or none of the submitting entities.

Pursuant to the authority of § 880 of the FY2017 NDAA, DHS has been vested with procedural discretion to make multiple contract awards resulting from the evaluation and determination of viable technology solutions. DHS has not established a pre-determined number of awards. The number of awards made, if any, may be impacted by various considerations, to include the quality of the submissions, DHS mission priorities, and the availability of funding. Proposals shall be evaluated on their individual merits rather than on a comparative basis. Besides the criterion described below, all proposed solutions must clearly demonstrate how the commercial item is offered in an innovative manner.

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Evaluation Criteria

The evaluation will include an assessment of whether the proposed commercial product or service is innovative within the meaning of the statute.

The following evaluation criteria will be used to evaluate Phase 1 submissions. The technical merit will be based on the following:

- Does the submission identify a problem being experienced by DHS under one of the Strategic Focus Areas?
- Does the submission describe an innovative viable solution and relevant application to the problem?
- Does the company describe differentiators, providing specific examples, evidence, and/or metrics that demonstrate the innovative value and advantage that it brings in the submission?

All individual Phase 1 submissions will be fairly evaluated, however, only those submissions that are innovative, commercial, and evaluated to hold technical merit will be invited to move forward with Phase 2. After evaluating Phase 1, the Contracting Officer will formally notify the Submitter whether they have been invited to participate in Phase 2, or if their solution did not meet the Government's need. Vendors who have not been selected to move to Phase 2 may request a brief explanation of non-selection. DHS reserves the right to invite any number of vendors to participate in Phase 2 throughout the open period of the General Solicitation.

Companies may not participate in Phase 2, if they did not submit a solution video for consideration under Phase 1.

Phase 2 - Development / Supplemental Information

Vendors that are found to be meritorious may be asked to participate in an interview-style oral presentation/technical demonstration (or similar) and/or provide additional supporting information regarding their proposed solution at the Government's discretion. The Government reserves the right to request oral presentations, technical demonstrations, or additional written information, if applicable, from one or more Submitters at any time during the Solicitation period.

If Submitters are invited to conduct an oral presentation/technical demonstration, the Submitter shall provide and be responsible for all costs related to the labor, supervision, tools, materials, equipment, transportation, and management necessary for an oral presentation/technical demonstration to be conducted under this General Solicitation. This is just a preliminary notice to industry for what Submitters shall be responsible for in the event a vendor is requested to conduct an oral presentation/technical demonstration.

Eventual awards will be made based on the following criteria:

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- Criterion I: Technical Merit – The potential of the proposed innovative commercial product and/or service proof of concept or viable prototype to meet the project goals as outlined in the focus area(s).
- Criterion II: Business Viability – The potential of the vendor, if the proof of concept and/or prototype are successful, to sustain performance during full implementation using a successful business model.
- Criterion III: Price – Whether the price (1) reflects a sufficient understanding of the technical goals and objectives of the General Solicitation; (2) is consistent with the vendor's technical approach; (3) is developed based on realistic assumptions, and (4) is fair and reasonable.

All resulting CSOP awards are subject to the availability of DHS funding.

Following the evaluation of Phase 2, DHS will notify each vendor if they have been selected to move to Phase 3, or if their solution is no longer being considered for an award. Following the selection and notification to move to Phase 3, selected vendors will work with the Government to develop a proposal inclusive of a written statement of work/performance work statement, price submission, and appropriate terms and conditions. It is within the Government's discretion to accept more than one solution brief for an award resulting from this Solicitation.

Phase 3 – Award

Based on the Phase 1 & 2 evaluations, in accordance with the CSOP authority, the Government may enter directly into negotiations with selected vendor(s) to make a resultant award(s).

Acquisition Pathways for Awardable Submissions

The process for award will vary based upon requiring activity need, type of solution, solution maturity, and structure of the solution provider. All solutions which are assessed as awardable have satisfied the competition requirements of the Competition in Contracting Act (CICA) of 1984; however, the award of such solutions may require the vendor and Government customer to collaboratively develop and negotiate a scope of effort, pricing, project milestones and deliverables, period of performance, relevant terms and conditions and a definition of successful completion for the effort. Ultimately, the choice of the award vehicle will be determined by the nature of the offering and after coordination with the vendor and the expectations of the program and may be awarded by DHS and any Component under a Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) procurement instrument or non-FAR authority.

Upon favorable review and subject to available funds, the Government may choose to make an award(s).

The vendor must be determined to be responsible and must not be suspended or debarred from award by the Government nor be prohibited by Presidential Executive Order and/or

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law from receiving award.

The Government reserves the right to cancel the Solicitation at any time. In addition, the Government may make the determination not to move forward with negotiations and/ or an award during each Phase.

Definition of Terms

- **Commercial Product or Service** has the meaning given the term “commercial product” or “commercial service” in sections 103 and 103a, respectively, of title 41, United States Code.
- **Innovative**, within the meaning of the statute, is any new technology, process, or method, including research and development; or any new application of an existing technology, process, or method.
- **Peer Review** is an evaluation process using subject matter experts to evaluate the technical, scientific, and business merit of proposals in meeting Agency needs as stated in the General Solicitation.

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Appendix A – Other Terms and Conditions

Additional terms and conditions will be negotiated between the Government and Vendor for each individual resulting CSOP contract award(s).

- **Government Contacts**

- All submissions/correspondence related to this General Solicitation shall be directed to the following mailbox:
 - parminfo@hq.dhs.gov
- The DHS points of contact are:
 - Contracting Officer
 - Breean.Jaroski@hq.dhs.gov
 - Contract Specialist
 - Mariah.Watt@hq.dhs.gov

- **The following FAR Provisions are hereby included by Reference:**

- FAR 52.204-24, Representation Regarding Certain Telecommunications and Video Surveillance Services or Equipment
- FAR at 52.204-26, Covered Telecommunications Equipment or Services-Representation
- FAR 52.204-29, Federal Acquisition Supply Chain Security Act Orders – Representation and Disclosures

- **The following FAR Clauses are hereby included by Reference:**

- FAR 52.203-16, Preventing Personal Conflicts of Interest;
- FAR 52.203-17, Contractor Employee Whistleblower Rights and Requirement to Inform Employees of Whistleblower Rights;
- FAR 52.204-23, Prohibition on Contracting for Hardware, Software, and Services Developed or Provided by Kaspersky Lab Covered Entities, and DHS FAR Deviation 20-05, Rev 3 (JUL 2024)
- FAR 52.204-25, Prohibition on Certain Telecommunications and Video Surveillance Services or Equipment, and DHS FAR Class Deviation 20-05, Rev 3 (DEC 2020)
- FAR 52.204-28, Federal Acquisition Supply Chain Security Act Orders – Federal Supply Schedules, Governmentwide Acquisition Contracts, and Multi-Agency Contracts
- FAR 52.204-30, Federal Acquisition Supply Chain Security Act Orders – Prohibition.
- FAR 52.222-50, Combating Trafficking in Persons; and
- FAR 52.222-54. Employment Eligibility Verification.

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- FAR Clause 52.204-27, Prohibition on a ByteDance Covered Application
- Additional FAR and supplemental DHS Clauses will be identified and included in the resulting CSOP contract awards(s).
- **Intellectual Property:**
 - Intellectual Property rights shall be negotiated prior to a resulting contract award with those submitters deemed to have submitted a successful solution. The mutually agreed upon intellectual property terms and conditions shall be inserted into the resulting awarded contract.
- **DHS Cyber Hygiene Clauses:**
 - DHS will include specific Cyber Hygiene Clauses based on the proposed solutions in all resulting awards.
- **Term of the General Solicitation:**
 - The Solicitation will remain open for a period of 12 months, concluding on August 5, 2026. This is an open call Solicitation, inviting industry participants to submit their responses at any time during this period.
- **Protest**
 - Protests under CSOP awards shall be adjudicated as prescribed under DHS Component- level protest procedures.
 - Contractors may seek assistance from the Agency Advocate for Competition. The Department Advocate for Competition and Procuring Activity Advocates for Competition are listed on the Doing Business with DHS page, accessible at:
 - <https://www.dhs.gov/competition-advocates-and-task-order-and-delivery-order-ombudsman>.
- **Payments:**
 - The CSOP statute does not authorize advance payments.
 - Additional payment terms will be established during Phase 3.

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